

Roots

THE ROOT IS THE PART OF A WORD THAT CONTAINS MEANING, EVEN WITHOUT A PREFIX OR SUFFIX.

SEE ALSO

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◀ 138–139 Understanding English irregularities

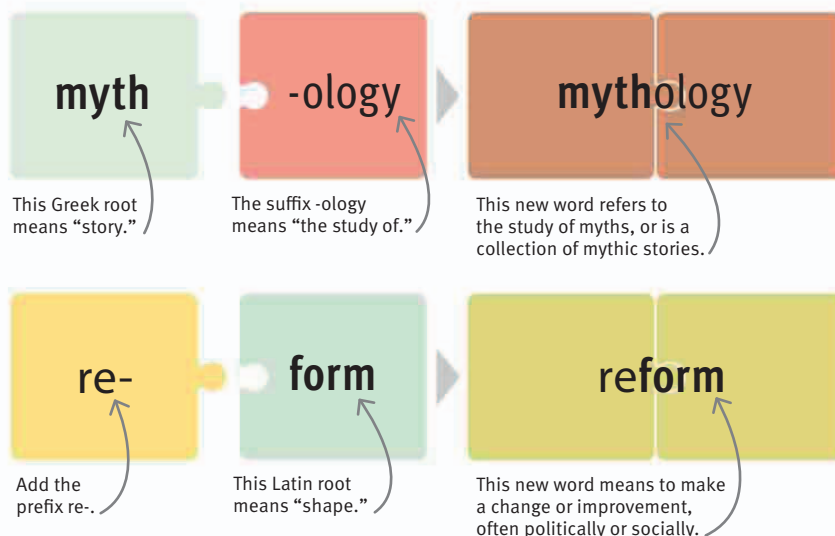
Prefixes and suffixes

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A root can be an existing English word or part of a word, and it usually originates from Latin or Greek. Learning to identify roots can help with spelling and building vocabulary.

Whole root words

English includes many whole root words, which often stem from Greek or Latin. These words cannot be separated into smaller words, since they are already in their simplest form. However, a whole root word can be made longer by adding a prefix or suffix. For example, the word *build* can become *building*, *builder* and *rebuild*. Each new word has a different meaning, but they are all related to the whole root word.



Partial root words

The root is not always a complete English word. Adding a suffix, or a prefix and a suffix, however, can extend a Latin or Greek root to create a recognizable English word. For example, the Latin word *aud*, meaning "hear," forms the root of many familiar English words, including *audio*, *audience*, *audition*, and *auditorium*. Although these words mean different things, they are all related to the original root word.

